

The Second Sex

Until the late 20th century, philosophy was almost exclusively a male preserve. The few female philosophers had been overshadowed by their male counterparts, and those who were noticed tended to be political activists more than mainstream philosophers. Simone de Beauvoir, however, took existentialism as a framework for her politics. In *The Second Sex*, she showed that male-dominated society defined what it is to be a woman: man is defined as a human being, but woman as a female. She believed there is a difference between being physically female and the social construct of femininity – ‘one is not born but becomes a woman’. As an existentialist, like her lover Sartre, she believed we are free to choose the values that define us and to create ourselves rather than accept existing norms. Women, therefore, should break free from conventional passive femininity, and also from ideas that they should emulate men, and choose for themselves an authentic existence as women. Written in 1949, *The Second Sex* inspired both the Women’s Liberation movement of the 1960s, and ‘second wave’ feminism.



Women's liberation protesters take to the streets of Washington DC, 1970.